

Decoding the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly Election

A fact-based data story in three chapters

Turnout Earthquake

The Great Flip

Vote Share Reshuffle

One Election. Three Connected Stories.

The turnout surge, vote shift, and seat flips were not separate events — they were chapters of the same story.

01

THE TURNOUT SURGE

Tamil Nadu hit **85.1%** — a state record. Chennai Metro went from last to first, surging **+29pp**. Women outpaced men in **168 of 234** constituencies.

02

THE GREAT FLIP

163 of **234** seats (**70%**) changed their winning party. **80%** of the top-20 turnout-surge ACs flipped — almost all to TVK.

03

THE VOTE SHIFT

TVK built **34.9%** from zero, absorbing defectors from DMK (−13.5pp) and AIADMK (−12.1pp). NOTA protest votes collapsed **42%**.

TURNOUT

85.1% — Tamil Nadu Breaks Its Own Record

85.1%

State avg turnout 2026

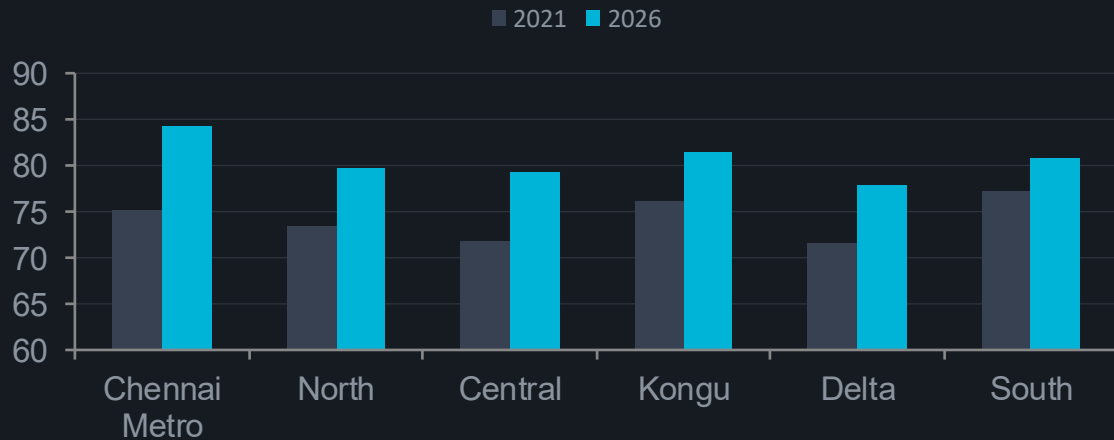
+4.6pp

Avg increase vs 2021

16 / 20

Top surge ACs that flipped

Turnout by Region — 2021 vs 2026 (%)



Key Patterns

- Chennai Metro surged hardest — +9.4pp avg
- Every region crossed 77% — no laggards
- 80% of top-20 surge ACs flipped seats
- Women outpaced men in 168 of 234 ACs
- Highest: Karur at 94.4% turnout

Women Didn't Just Keep Up — They Led the Surge

Female turnout rose 13.6pp (72.6→86.2%); male rose 10.9pp (72.9→83.8%). The gap widened in 2026.

168 / 234

ACs where women turnout > men in 2026

83 / 234

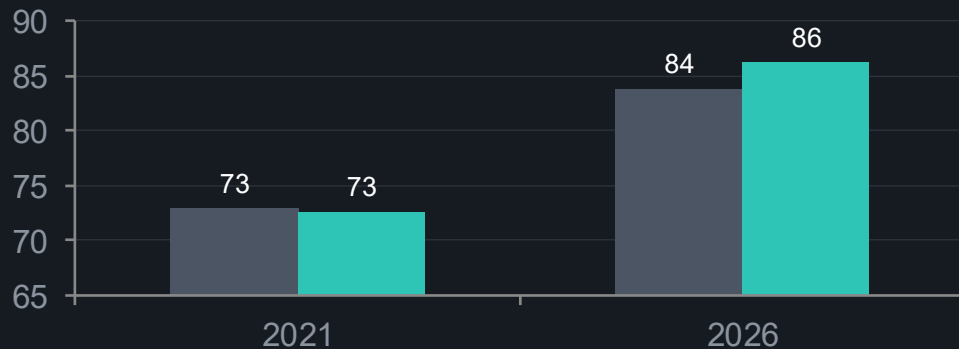
Same metric in 2021 — 2× increase

+2.4pp

Female over male turnout advantage 2026

Male vs Female Turnout (%)

■ Male ■ Female



Why This Matters

- Female turnout exceeded male in 2× more ACs vs 2021
- +1.7pp female advantage was consistent across all 6 regions
- Third gender turnout: 58.5% — still 27pp below female
- +13.6pp female turnout gain since 2021 vs +10.9pp for male

Higher-Literacy Districts Surged the Hardest in 2026

In 2021, literacy correlated negatively with turnout ($r=-0.72$). By 2026, that relationship nearly reversed — literacy now predicts surge.

$$r = -0.72$$

Literacy vs turnout 2021

High literacy = lower turnout

$$r = -0.45$$

Literacy vs turnout 2026

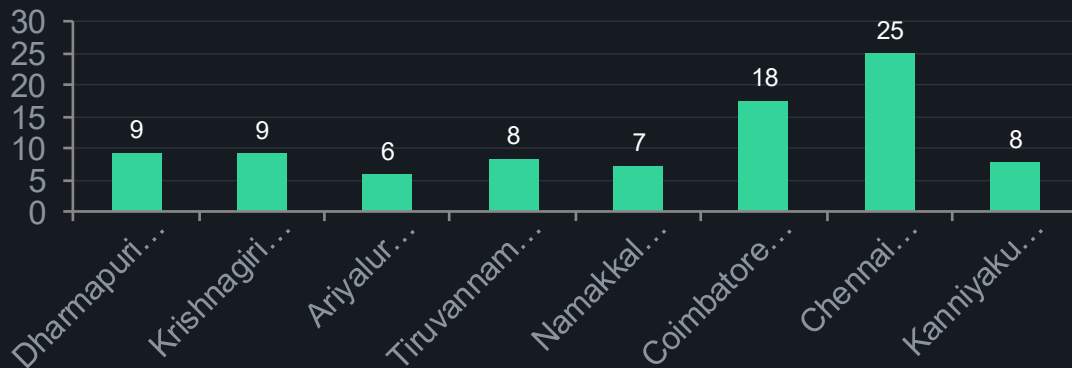
Relationship weakened

$$r = +0.43$$

Literacy vs turnout surge

High literacy surged more

Turnout Surge by District (literacy % shown in label)



The Reversal Story

- Chennai (+25pp) and Coimbatore (+17.5pp) — high-literacy, historically low-turnout — led the surge
- High literacy districts averaged +13.3pp surge vs +9.5pp for low literacy
- Low-literacy districts already voted at high rates in 2021 — less room to grow
- Pattern consistent with TVK's urban, educated voter mobilisation

SEAT FLIPS

163 of 234 Seats Changed Hands — The Biggest Swing in a Generation

163

Seats Flipped (70%)

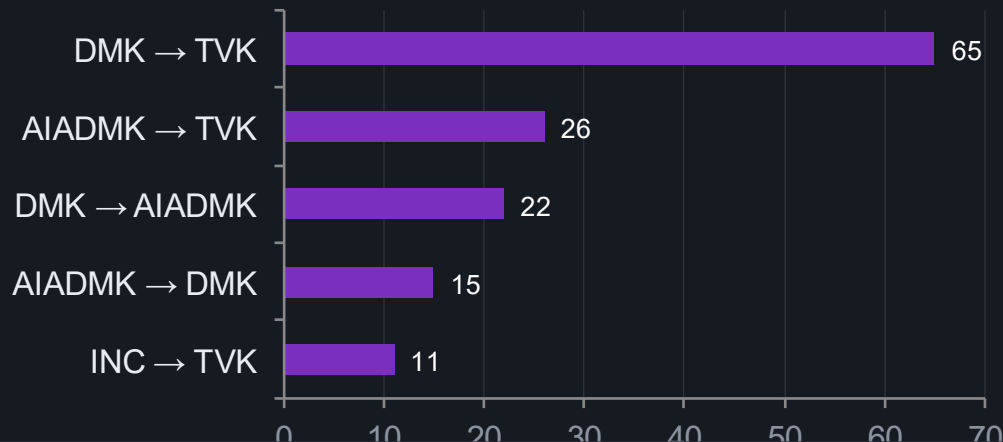
108

TVK Winners

94%

Chennai Metro Flip Rate

Top Seat Transitions 2021→2026

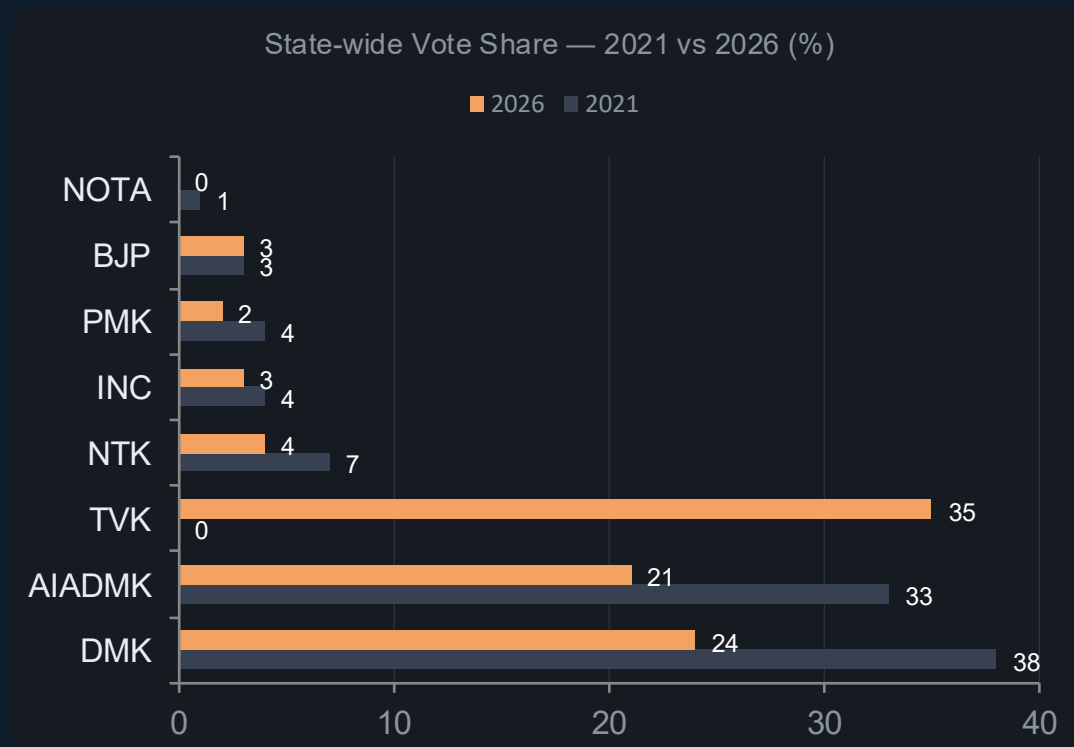


Flips by Region

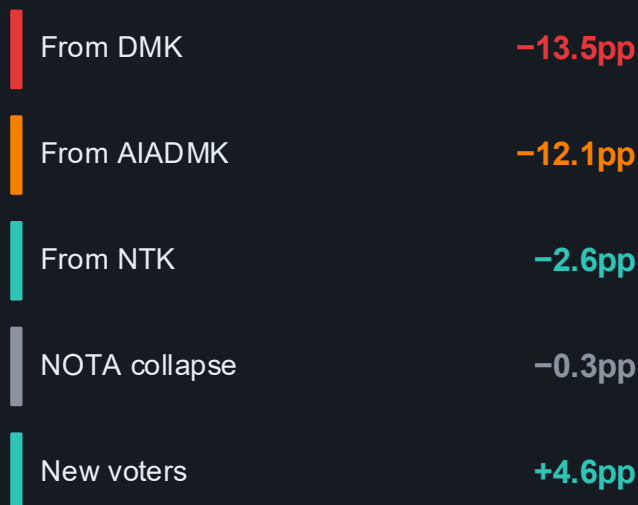
South	38 seats · avg 7.9pp swing
Chennai Metro	30 seats · avg 6.0pp swing
North	27 seats · avg 10.0pp swing
Kongu	27 seats · avg 9.8pp swing
Central	26 seats · avg 11.3pp swing
Delta	15 seats · avg 9.8pp swing

📍 Tirupattur: TVK won by 1 vote · Edappadi: AIADMK won by 98,110 votes

TVK Got 34.9% From Zero — Where Did Those Votes Come From?

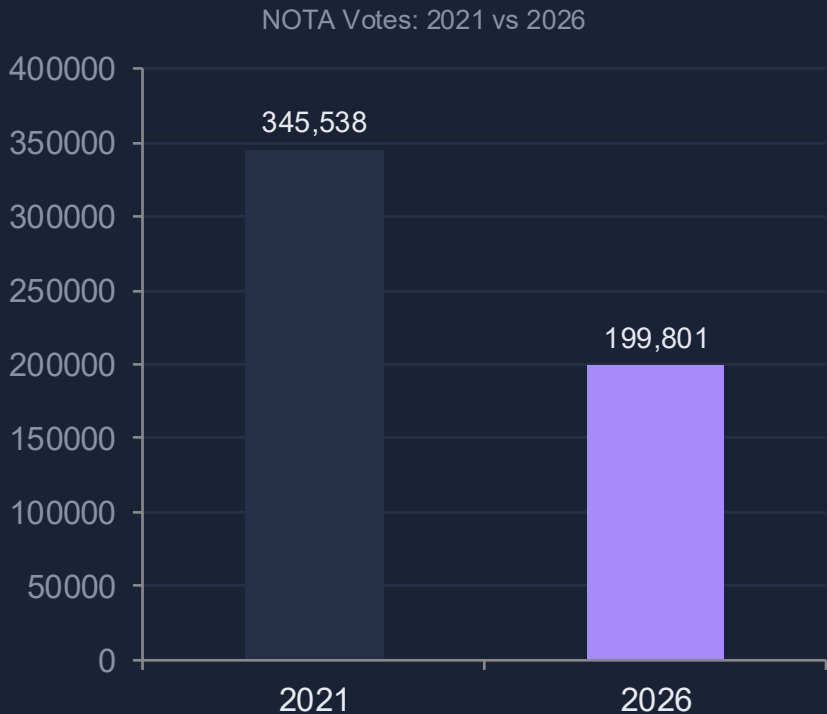


Where TVK Votes Came From



TVK absorbed votes from every direction — biggest source: defectors from both major parties.

145,737 Protest Votes Disappeared — They Went to TVK

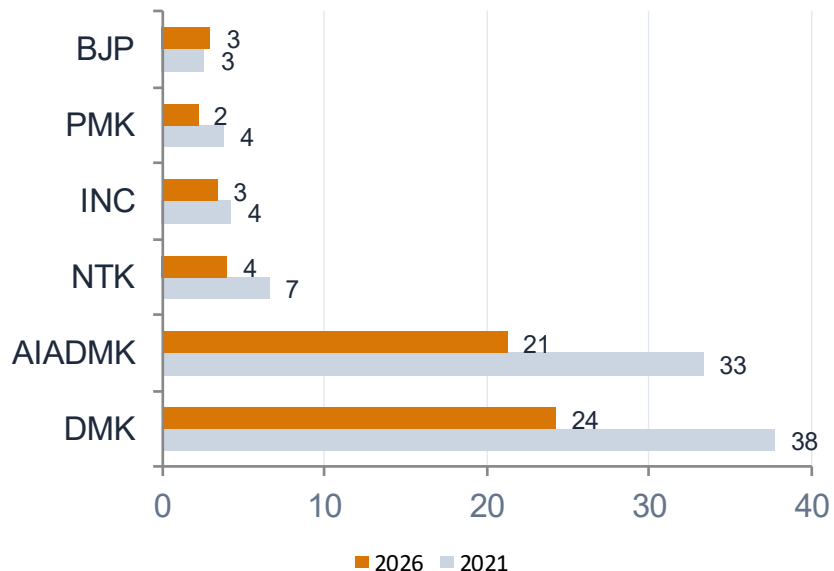


What the NOTA collapse tells us

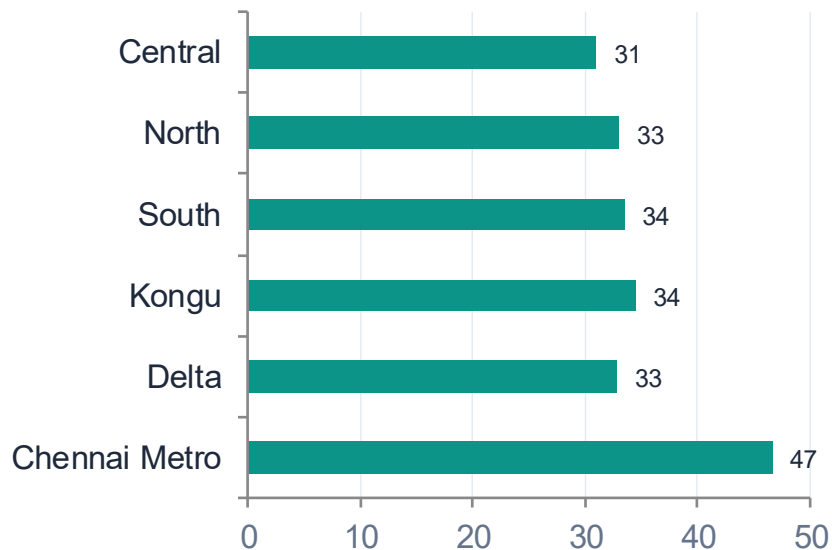
- 345,538 → 199,801 — a 42% drop in protest votes
- 145,737 voters who pressed NOTA in 2021 chose a real candidate in 2026
- TVK gave disenchanted voters a viable alternative for the first time
- NOTA % fell from 0.75% to 0.41% — even as total turnout rose
- Biggest NOTA drops were in constituencies TVK won by large margins

TVK's Vote Share Was Consistent Across All Six Regions

Top Parties Vote Share (excl. TVK — new in 2026)



TVK Vote Share by Region 2026 — Statewide avg 34.9%



TVK's range: 31–47% across all 6 regions — not a Chennai story, a statewide structural shift

What the Data Can & Cannot Tell Us

LIMITATIONS

- Seat flows are constituency-level — individual voter switching cannot be inferred from ECI data
- Six-region grouping is editorial; district-level analysis may show different sub-patterns
- Literacy correlations indicate association only — causation cannot be established
- Gender data is elector-roll level; party preference by gender cannot be linked without exit polls

EDITORIAL ANGLES TO EXPLORE

1. Commission district-level exit polls for 2031 to test the voter-switch hypothesis
2. Explore SC/ST reserved constituencies — did they mirror or deviate from the state trend?
3. Micro-story: Tiruppattur's 1-vote margin — what drives hyperlocal contests?
4. Ground reporting: what drove the 13.6pp surge in female turnout?

Three Stories for AtliQ's One-Hour Show

1 Open with the Turnout Story

Universal — every viewer voted or knows someone who did. The Chennai Metro surge (+29pp) and the gender flip (168 seats where women outvoted men) are visual, human, and surprising.

2 Follow with the Flip Story

163 seat changes keep the show moving. The 1-vote margin at Tiruppattur is a broadcast-ready moment. The seat transitions chart gives the anchor a clean visual to walk through.

3 Close with Vote Share

The re-ordering of parties — including a new entrant at 34.9% — is the structural story beneath the seat count. End here so viewers leave with the big-picture takeaway.

All findings are based solely on ECI official data. This analysis is non-partisan.

THANK YOU

Decoding the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly Election

Story 1 — Record Turnout: 86.2% state average; Chennai Metro surged 25–31pp; women outvoted men in 168/234 seats

Story 2 — The Great Flip: 163 of 234 seats changed party (70%); only 71 held; Tiruppattur won by 1 vote

Story 3 — TVK's Rise: 34.92% from zero; consistent 31–47% across all 6 regions; absorbed NOTA protest voters

Connection: The surge, the flips, and the vote share are the same story told three ways